

Tweeny BOPPERS

The boys are dandy and the girls want to be eye candy. As children develop earlier, precocious pre-teens challenge accepted notions of parenting and teaching.

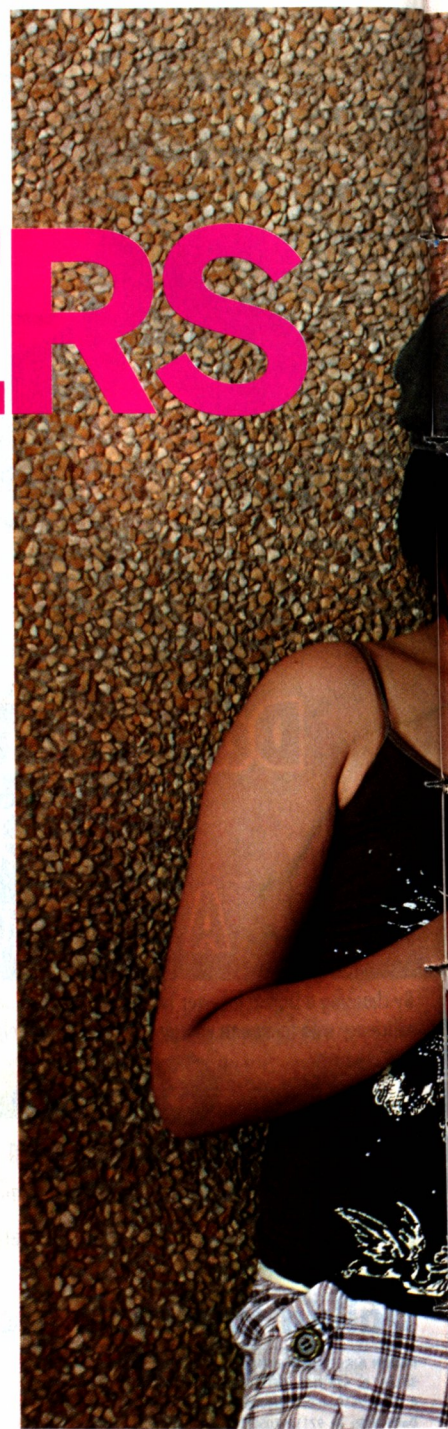
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It's a world where tweens are the new teens. Where naughty nine is the new sweet sixteen. Where coolness is measured by your relationship status on Facebook, where a tattoo is a necessary accessory, where birthday parties are held in pubs, and where sleepovers are an essential rite of adolescent passage. It's where girls experiment with make-up and boys discover deodorants. Where skirt hems go up and trouser waists go down. Where the mall has replaced the playground and the *adda* has made way for the online chat. Where Enid Blytons lie untouched while Hannah Montanas and Sweet Valley are being devoured. Where G.I. Joes and toy cars have been replaced by PSPs and iPhones. It's called accelerated adolescence and it's changing the notion of childhood.

LIFE IN THE FAST LANE

Exploring their own growing bodies

Children are hitting puberty earlier than ever. Partly explained by better nutrition and partly by greater exposure to media which causes irregular sleep and sustained exposure to light,



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